

He was pretty frugal sometimes; and when I was young and we went somewhere on business, I had to share a hotel room with him. We did this even after I could afford my own room because he couldn't handle the notion of me "wasting" the money. When I was about thirty, I just couldn't do it any more. But one night in the early 1970's, we were together in Monterey at one of the first elaborate dog-and-pony shows for technology stocks—then known as "The Monterey Conference"—put on by the American Electronics Association. At the Monterey Conference, Father exhibited another quality I never forgot. The conference announced a dinner contest. There was a card at each place setting, and each person was to write down what he or she thought the Dow Jones Industrials would do the next day, which is, of course, a silly exercise. The cards were collected. The person who came closest to the Dow's change for the day would win a mini-color TV (which were hot new items then). The winner would be announced at lunch the next day, right after the market closed at one o'clock (Pacific time). Most folks, it turned out, did what I did—wrote down some small number, like down or up 5.57 points. I did that assuming that the market was unlikely to do anything particularly spectacular because most days it doesn't. Now in those days, the Dow was at about 900, so 5 points was neither huge nor tiny. That night, back at the hotel room, I asked Father what he put down; and he said, "Up 30 points," which would be more than 3 per-cent. I asked why. He said he had no idea at all what the market would do; and if you knew him, you knew that he never had a view of what the market would do on a given day. But he said that if he put down a number like I did and won, people would think he was just lucky—that winning at 5.57 meant beating out the guy that put down 5.5 or the other guy at 6.0. It would all be transparently seen as sheer luck. But if he won saying, "Up 30 points," people would think he knew something and was not just lucky. If he lost, which was probable and he expected to, no one would know what number he had written down, and it would cost him nothing. Sure enough, the next day, the Dow was up 26 points, and father won by 10 points.

When it was announced at lunch that Phil Fisher had won and how high his number was, there were discernable "Ooh" and "Ahhhh" sounds all over the few-hundred-person crowd. There was, of course, the news of the day, which attempted to explain the move; and for the rest of that conference, Father readily explained to people a rationale for why he had figured out all that news in advance, which was pure fiction, and why the market had done